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The Dark Forest (Remembrance of Earth's Past)

by Cixin Liu, Joel Martinsen

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139 Highlights | 10 Notes

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 5

DRAMATIS PERSONAE ORGANIZATIONS ETO Earth-Trisolaris Organization PDC Planetary Defense Council SFJC Solar Fleet Joint Conference CAST OF CHARACTERS Chinese names are written with surname first. Luo Ji Astronomer and sociologist Ye Wenjie Astrophysicist Mike Evans ETO financial backer and key leader Wu Yue Captain in the PLA Navy Zhang Beihai Political commissar in the PLA Navy; Space Force officer Chang Weisi General in the PLA; Space Force commander George Fitzroy US general; coordinator at the Planetary Defense Council; military liaison to Hubble II project Albert Ringier Hubble II astronomer Zhang Yuanchao Recently retired chemical plant worker in Beijing Yang Jinwen Retired middle school teacher in Beijing Miao Fuquan Shanxi coal boss; neighbor to Zhang and Yang Shi Qiang PDC security department officer, nicknamed Da Shi Shi Xiaoming Shi Qiang's son Kent Liaison to the PDC Secretary General Say Secretary general of the UN Frederick Tyler Former US secretary of defense Manuel Rey Diaz Former president of Venezuela Bill Hines English neuroscientist; former president of the EU Keiko Yamasuki Neuroscientist; Hines's wife Garanin PDC rotating chair Ding Yi Theoretical physicist Zhuang Yan Graduate of the Central Academy of Fine Arts Ben Jonathan Fleet Joint Conference special commissioner Dongfang Yanxu Captain of Natural Selection Major Xizi Science officer of Quantum

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 9

At the right angle where the foot of the formation met the ground, there was a spider web. This, the ant knew. It carefully detoured around the sticky hanging strands, passing by the spider lying in wait, its legs extended to feel for vibrations in the threads. Each knew of the other's presence but—as it had been for eons—there was no communication.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 11

Down on the formation, the ant wanted to turn toward the sky, but then discovered another trough ahead of it, identical to the “9”-shaped trough it had crawled through before the “7.” So it continued horizontally through the “9,” which it found better than both the “7” and the “1.” although it could not say exactly why. Its aesthetic sense was primitive and single-celled. The indistinct pleasure it had felt upon crawling through the “9” intensified. A primitive, single-celled state of happiness. These two spiritual monocells, aesthetics and pleasure had never evolved. They had been the same a billion years ago, and would be the same a billion years hence.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 13

“See how the stars are points? The factors of chaos and randomness in the complex makeup of every civilized society in the universe get filtered out by the distance, so those civilizations can act as reference points that are relatively easy to manipulate mathematically.” “But there’s nothing concrete to study in your cosmic sociology, Dr. Ye. Surveys and experiments aren’t really possible.” “That means your ultimate result will be purely theoretical. Like Euclidean geometry, you’ll set up a few simple axioms at first, then derive an overall theoretic system using those axioms as a foundation.” “It’s all fascinating, but what would the axioms of cosmic sociology be?” “First: Survival is the primary need of civilization. Second: Civilization continuously grows and expands, but the total matter in the universe remains constant.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 14

“I’ve been thinking about this for most of my life, but I’ve never spoken about it with anyone before. I don’t know why, really.... One more thing: To derive a basic picture of cosmic sociology from these two axioms, you need two other important concepts: chains of suspicion, and the technological explosion.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 15

Without the fear of heights, there can be no appreciation for the beauty of high places.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 30

In the words of his neighbor Lao Yang,³ today was the start of his second childhood. Lao Yang told him that sixty, like sixteen, was the best time in life, an age where the burdens of one’s forties and fifties had been laid down, but the slowdown and illness of the seventies and eighties had not yet arrived. An age to enjoy life.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 46

The US government said that no form of socialized technology was realistic, that it was a naïve idea, and that under the present circumstances US national security was a priority “second only to planetary defense.” The failure of the limited socialized technology proposal caused a split among technological powers and led to the bankruptcy of the plan to establish a United Earth Space Force. The implications of the frustrated socialized technology movement are far-reaching, and people have been made aware that even in the face of the devastating Trisolar Crisis, the unity of the human race is still a distant dream.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 48

I’ve recently been studying A Story of Three Kingdoms, and like you said, deceit and trickery are an art, just like the markings on a snake.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 51

The ships will take off in about one hundred twenty years.” “That’s pretty quick. Can they be built in time?” “Uncle Zhang, think back to what things were like one hundred twenty years ago. It was still the Qing Dynasty!

It took over a month to go from Hangzhou to Beijing, and the emperor had to spend days cooped up in a sedan chair to get to his summer retreat. Now it's less than three days from Earth to the moon. Technology develops fast, which means that the pace of development is always on the increase. If you add to that the fact that the whole world is pouring all its energy into space technology, then there's no question at all that spaceships can be created in about one hundred twenty years."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 60

By an overwhelming majority, a special session of the United Nations General Assembly passed a resolution declaring Escapism a violation of international law. In strong language, the resolution condemned the division and turmoil that Escapism has created within human society, and described Escapism as a crime against humanity in the eyes of international law.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 60

In a statement, the Chinese delegate reiterated the stance of the Chinese government regarding Escapism and said that it firmly supports UN Resolution 117.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 60

He concluded by saying, "We must cherish the unity and solidarity of the international community in this time of crisis and uphold the principle, recognized by the international community, that all humanity has an equal right to survival.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 60

Inequality of survival is the worst sort of inequality, and the people and countries left behind will never just sit and wait for death while others have a way out. There will be increasingly extreme confrontations between the two sides until there's world chaos, and then no one goes! The UN resolution is quite wise.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 64

"Beihai, you've got a long way to go. I say that because I can still easily understand you, and being understandable to me means that your mind is still too simple, not subtle enough. On the day I can no longer read you or figure you out, but you can easily understand me, that's when you'll finally have grown up."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 66

The three of them left the room and followed the corridor to the elevator. The ceiling was lined with rectangular metal ductwork and they passed several heavy, sealed doorways. Luo Ji noticed a faint slogan on one of the mottled walls. Only part of it was visible, but he knew the whole slogan: "Dig deep tunnels, keep vast stores of grain, don't seek hegemony."⁸ "Civil Air Defense?" he asked. "Not the ordinary kind. Defense against the atom bomb, but it's obsolete now. Back in the day, you had to be someone special to get in here."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 71

“I don’t know anything about space warfare, of course, but if you want to compare it to a wooden boat versus a carrier, then I think it’s just a matter of having the courage to act and the confidence in a victory. A wooden boat could carry a small squad of divers who’ll wait in the carrier’s path. When the enemy draws near, they’ll dive in and the boat will leave. Then when the carrier comes close, they’ll attach a bomb to the bottom of the hull and sink the carrier.... Of course this would be exceedingly difficult, but it’s not impossible.” Wu Yue nodded. “Not bad. People have tried it before. In the Second World War, the British did that as part of the effort to sink the Tirpitz, only they used a minisub. In the 1980s, during the Malvinas War, a few Argentine special forces soldiers took Italian limpet mines into Spain and attempted to blow up a British warship docked in the harbor at Gibraltar.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 72

A one- or two-thousand-ton nuclear bomb can be made small enough for one or two divers to take underwater, and when it’s attached to the underside of a carrier, it won’t just sink it, it’ll blow the whole carrier to smithereens.” “Sometimes you’ve got a fantastic imagination,” Wu Yue said with a smile. “I’ve got confidence in our victory.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 87

The highest level of literary creation is when the characters in a novel possess life in the mind of the writer. The writer is unable to control them, and might not even be able to predict the next action they will take. We can only follow them in wonder to observe and record the minute details of their lives like a voyeur. That’s how a classic is made.” “So literature, it turns out, is a perverted endeavor.” “It was like that for Shakespeare and Balzac and Tolstoy, at least.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 92

For the majority of people, what they love exists only in the imagination. The object of their love is not the man or woman of reality, but what he or she is like in their imagination. The person in reality is just a template used for the creation of this dream lover. Eventually, they find out the differences between their dream lover and the template. If they can get used to those differences, then they can be together. If not, they split up. It’s as simple as that.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 100

We shall call them the Wallfacers because that ancient Eastern name for meditators mirrors the unique characteristics of their work. As they direct the execution of their strategic plans, the thoughts and behaviors these Wallfacers present to the outside world will be entirely false, a carefully crafted mélange of disguise, misdirection, and deception. The subject of this misdirection and deception will be the entire world, both enemy and ally, until a huge, bewildering maze of illusions is erected to make the enemy lose its judgment, and to delay as long as possible the moment it works out our true strategic intent.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 104

During research conducted with the neuroscientist Keiko Yamasuki, he discovered that brain activity for thoughts and memories operated on the quantum level rather than on the molecular level as previously believed. This discovery pushed brain mechanisms downward to the microstate of matter, rendering all prior research nothing more than superficial attempts that merely skimmed the surface of neuroscience. This discovery also demonstrated that the animal brain's capacity to process information was several orders of magnitude higher than previously imagined, which lent credence to long-held speculation that the brain had a holographic structure.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 127

"We must establish faith in victory, a faith that is the foundation of military duty and dignity! When the Chinese military once faced a powerful enemy under extremely poor conditions, it established a firm faith in victory through a sense of responsibility to the people and the motherland. I believe that today, a sense of responsibility to the human race and to Earth civilization can encourage the same faith."

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 129

eight hundred kilometers per second.

1,789,549.03 mph

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 129

forty-eight hundred kilometers per second.

10,737,294.2 mph

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 129

sixteen thousand kilometers per second, which is five percent of the speed of light.

35,790,980.7

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 134

"These displays are obsolete," Rey Diaz said. "But behind them is the most powerful computer in the world, operating at thirty petaFLOPS."

1petaflop= 1K million million (10¹⁵) operations per sec

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 138

The outcome of natural biological evolution requires at least twenty thousand years to manifest itself, but human civilization has just five thousand years of history, and modern technological civilization just two hundred. That

means that the study of modern science today is being done by the brain of primitive man.” “You want to use technology to accelerate the brain’s evolution?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 145

schadenfreude

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 148

“An astrophysicist. An authority on stars.” “What’s he going to do?” “That’s what I’m gonna tell you. To your mind, a nuclear bomb is detonated and then explodes, but the actual process is more like burning. The greater the yield, the longer the combustion. A twenty-megaton nuclear explosion, for example, has a fireball that can last for over twenty seconds. The superbomb we’re designing is two hundred megatons, and its fireball will burn for several minutes. Think about that. What will it look like?” “A small sun.” “Correct! Its fusion structure is very like that of a star, and it reproduces stellar evolution over a very abbreviated period. So the mathematical model we need to construct is essentially the model of a star.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 163

“I like traditional painting.” “What’s that got to do with snowcaps?” “Mr. Luo, are you aware of the difference between traditional painting and oil painting? Oil paintings are brimming with rich colors. A master once said that in oil painting, white is as precious as gold. But it’s different with traditional painting. There’s lots and lots of blank space, and blank space forms the painting’s eyes. The scenery is just the border for that blank space. Look at that snowy peak. Doesn’t it look like the blank space in a traditional painting?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 163

This was the most she had ever said to him. She lectured the Wallfacer, pouring out words and turning him into an ignorant schoolboy, without any sense of being out of line. You’re like the blank space in a traditional painting: pure, but to a mature appreciation, infinitely appealing, he thought as he looked at her.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 171

“Let it stay a legend. You have your wealth and technology. Legends are all we have.”

You have all the watches, we have all the time.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 172

“On the one hand, thanks to our common enemy, our hatred of the West has faded. On the other, the human race that the Trisolarans want to wipe out includes the hated West, so to us, perishing together would be a joy. So we don’t hate the Trisolarans.” The old man spread his hands. “You see, hatred is a treasure more precious than gold or diamonds, and a weapon keener than any in the world, but now it’s gone. It’s not yours to give back. So the organization, like me, does not have long to live.”

The muslim terrorist organization(s) need hatred to survive

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 172

the Seldon Plan

Asimov

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 180

And so it was that the Wallfacer and the young woman stood, gazes locked, in front of the smile of Mona Lisa in the Louvre in the dead of night.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 184

General, we're looking at the Trisolaran Fleet."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 192

Research is a process of leaping forward, and qualitative change is only produced by long-term quantitative accumulation. Breakthroughs in theory and technology are mostly achieved in concentrated bursts....

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 202

The love of his wife and child blended together and intoxicated his soul, and, in this gentle home isolated from the rest of the world, he had fallen deeper and deeper into an illusion: Perhaps the outside world really was something akin to a quantum state, and did not exist unless he observed it.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 203

everything has an ending. The sun and the universe will die one day, so why should humanity believe that it ought to be immortal?

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 203

Fighting a hopeless war is a fool's errand, so look at the Trisolar Crisis from a different perspective and leave your cares behind. Not just the ones involving the crisis, but everything else from before that. Use the time that's left to enjoy life. Four hundred years! Or, if we refuse the Doomsday Battle, then nearly five hundred. That's a fair amount of time. Humanity used the same period to go from the Renaissance to the information age, and in the same space could create a carefree, comfortable life. Five idyllic centuries without needing to worry about the distant future, where the sole responsibility is to enjoy life. How wonderful...."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 204

the number of simultaneous CT scans to several million, to be synthesized by computer into a digital model of the brain. Other technical requirements were even greater: The scan needed to be conducted at a rate of twenty-

four frames per second to produce a dynamic synthetic model that could capture all brain activity at a neuron-level resolution, making it possible to precisely observe thought activity in the brain, or even replay all neural activity throughout the thinking process.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 205

“Right now, computer technology based on traditional integrated circuits and Von Neumann architecture is nearing the limit of its technological development. Moore’s law is going to collapse. Of course, we can still squeeze out the last few drops of lemonade from these traditional electronic and technological lemons. In our opinion, even given the present deceleration in supercomputer progress, the computing power required by the two plans is still achievable. It just requires time. Optimistically, twenty to thirty years.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 213

“It’s a shame there’s no specific mission.” “Experience is the mission. A space strategist ought to have a consciousness of space. This wasn’t feasible before the space plane, since sending up one person cost tens of millions, but it’s much cheaper now. We’ll try to put more strategists into space soon, since we’re the space force, after all. Right now we’re more like a college of bullshit, and that just won’t do.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 218

Fitzroy arrived at the Hubble II Space Telescope Control Center early. Ringier laughed when he saw him. “General, why do you remind me of a child who wants another present so soon after Christmas?” “Didn’t you say that they would cross the snow patch today?” “That’s right, but the Trisolaran Fleet has only traveled 0.22 light-years, so it’s still four light-years away. Light reflected from its passage through the snow won’t reach Earth for another four years.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 218

“I’m sorry. We’re outside the light cone.” “What’s that?” “It’s what physicists call the cone shape that light describes as it emanates along the time axis. It’s impossible for people outside the cone to comprehend events taking place inside the cone. Think about it: Information about who-knows-how-many major events in the universe is flying toward us right now at the speed of light. Some of it has been traveling for hundreds of millions of years, but we’re still outside the light cones of those events.” “Fate lies within the light cone.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 219

He remembered back to middle school and a lesson a teacher had taught him for language arts exams: First, take a look at the final essay question, then start the exam from the top, so that as you work on the exam, your subconscious will be thinking over the essay question, like a background process in a computer.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 220

Secretary General Say had been wrong about one thing. Luo Ji’s never-begun research into cosmic sociology was quite likely the immediate reason why Trisolaris wanted to kill him. Of course, Say didn’t know that the

project had been Ye Wenjie's suggestion, and although it had just seemed to Luo Ji like an excellent opportunity to make scholarship entertaining, he had been looking for just such an opportunity. Prior to the Trisolar Crisis, the study of alien civilization was indeed a sensational project that would have garnered easy media attention. The aborted research project wasn't important in and of itself. What mattered was the instruction that Ye Wenjie had given him, so that's where Luo Ji's mind was stuck. Over and over again he recalled her words: Suppose a vast number of civilizations are distributed throughout the universe, on the order of the number of detectable stars. Lots and lots of them. The mathematical structure of cosmic sociology is far clearer than that of human sociology. The factors of chaos and randomness in the complex makeups of every civilized society in the universe get filtered out by the immense distance, so those civilizations can act as reference points that are relatively easy to manipulate mathematically. First: Survival is the primary need of civilization. Second: Civilization continuously grows and expands, but the total matter in the universe remains constant. One more thing: To derive a basic picture of cosmic sociology from these two axioms, you need two other important concepts: chains of suspicion and the technological explosion. I'm afraid there won't be that opportunity.... Well, you might as well just forget I said anything. Either way, I've fulfilled my duty. He had returned countless times to these words,

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 221

By this time, most of the prayer beads had been worn faint, except for twenty-one of them. These ones seemed only to get newer the more he polished them, and now emitted a faint light: Survival is the primary need of civilization. Civilization continuously grows and expands, but the total matter in the universe remains constant. He fixated on these two sentences, the axioms Ye Wenjie had proposed for cosmic civilization. Although he did not know their ultimate secret, his long meditation told him that the answer lay within them. But it was too simple a clue. What could he and the human race gain from two self-evident rules? Don't dismiss simplicity. Simple means solid. The entire mansion of mathematics was erected on a foundation of this kind of irreducibly simple, yet logically rock-solid, axiom.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 222

Like Ye Wenjie had said, the distance hid the complex structure of each star, making them just a collection of points in space with a clear mathematical configuration. It was a thinker's paradise, his paradise. To Luo Ji, at least, it felt like the world in front of him was far clearer and more concise than Darwin's. But this simple world held a perplexing riddle: The entire galaxy was a vast empty desert, but a highly intelligent civilization had appeared on the star nearest to us. In this mystery, his thoughts found an entry point. Gradually, the two concepts Ye Wenjie had left unexplained came into focus: chains of suspicion and the technology explosion.

Seeing the dark forest through the trees

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 227

Outside the Solar System, there are other stars with planets. You've discovered several hundred, right?" "More than a thousand to date." "And the closest to the sun?" "244J2E1, sixteen light-years from the sun." "As I remember it, the serial numbers are set like this: the prefix digits represent the order of discovery; the letters J, E, and X stand for Jupiter-type planets, Earth-type planets, and other planets, respectively; and the digits following

the letter indicate the number of that type of planet in the system.” “That’s right. 244J2E1 is a star with three planets, two of them Jupiter-type and one Earth-type.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 230

“I also made that request, but the Lord said the truth was the most important secret in the universe and could not be revealed. The Lord spoke of it with Evans under the impression that humanity already knew but later learned otherwise.” “Then ask the Lord to transfer technology!” Many other voices echoed this. Qin Shi Huang said, “This was another request I made. To my surprise, the Lord uncharacteristically did not reject it entirely.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 235

Luo Ji spent the night in a fevered torpor, haunted endlessly by restless dreams in which the stars in the night sky swirled and danced like grains of sand on the skin of a drum. He was even aware of the gravitational interaction between these stars: It wasn’t three-body motion, but the 200-billion-body motion of all of the stars in the galaxy! Then the swirling stars clustered into an enormous vortex, and in that mad spiral the vortex transformed again into a giant serpent formed from the congealed silver of every star, which drilled into his brain with a roar....

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 241

“I believe, not because I have any proof, but because it’s relatively safe: If there really is a God, then it’s right to believe in him. If there isn’t, then we don’t have anything to lose.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 242

Tianti III was the only space elevator based on the ocean. Its base was located on the Equator on an artificial floating island in the Pacific Ocean that could navigate at sea under its own nuclear power, which meant that the elevator’s position on the Equator could be adjusted if necessary. The floating island was a real-life version of the Propeller Island Jules Verne had described, and so it had been dubbed “Verne Island.” The ocean wasn’t even visible on the television, which was showing a shot of a metal, pyramid-shaped base surrounded by a steel city, and—at the bottom of the rail—the cylindrical transport cabin that was ready to launch. From this distance, the guide rail extending into space was invisible due to its sixty-centimeter diameter, although at times you could catch a glint of reflected light from the setting sun.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 244

“You know there’s an electromagnetic launcher at the end of Tianti. When it’s time, my casket will be fired off at the third cosmic velocity and will fly out of the Solar System. It’s called a cosmic burial, you know. After I die, I don’t want to stay on an alien-occupied Earth. It’s a form of Escapism, I guess.” “And if the aliens are defeated?” “That’s practically impossible. Still, if it really happens, it’s no great loss. I get to roam the universe!” Zhang Yuanchao shook his head. “You intellectuals with your weird ideas. They’re pointless. The fallen leaf returns to the root. I’m going to be buried in the yellow soil of the Earth.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 247

media-propelled spacecraft are just huge rockets. They have to devote two-thirds of their carrying capacity to their propulsion media, and it's consumed very quickly. That type of spacecraft requires planetary bases in order to navigate through the Solar System.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 247

A navy's front line defenses ought to be at the enemy's ports.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 247

"It's the old guard left over from the chemical rocket era that's pushing for media spacecraft, but forces from other disciplines have entered the sector. Take the people on our fusion system. They're mostly pushing for radiation spacecraft.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 248

"This is the most critical decision in the entire master strategy. If it's a misstep, the space fleet will be built atop a mistaken foundation, and we might waste a century or two.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 248

When Zhang Beihai entered the home of the meteorite collector, situated in a courtyard house in the depths of a hutong alleyway, he noticed that the old, dimly lit home was like a miniature geological museum. Each of its four walls was lined with glass cases in which professional lights shone on rock after unremarkable rock. The owner, in his fifties, hale in spirit and complexion, sat at a workbench examining a small stone with a magnifying lens, and he greeted the visitor warmly when he saw him. He was, Zhang Beihai noticed immediately, one of those fortunate people who inhabited a beloved world of his own. No matter what changes befell the larger world, he could always immerse himself in his own and find contentment.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 248

The completion of the space elevator and the breakthrough in controlled fusion technology were two enormous encouragements to the world, and eased defeatist sentiment to a considerable extent. But sober leaders were aware that this was only the beginning: If the construction of the space fleet was analogous to naval fleets, then humanity had just now arrived at the seashore, carrying tools.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 249

"Over a decade ago I went with a survey team to Antarctica in search of meteorites buried beneath the snow, and I got hooked. They come from outside of Earth, from distant space, so naturally they've got that attraction. Whenever I pick one up, it's like I'm going to a new and alien world." Zhang Beihai shook his head with a smile. "That's just a feeling. The Earth itself is formed out of aggregated interstellar matter, so it's basically just

a giant meteorite. The stone beneath our feet is meteorite. This teacup I'm holding is meteorite. Besides, they say that the water on Earth was brought here by comets, so"—he raised the teacup—"what's contained in this cup is meteorite, too. There's nothing particularly special about what you have." The collector pointed at him and laughed. "You're sharp. You've already started to bargain.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 252

three hundred kilometers

186 miles

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 254

As people became used to the environment of space, they gradually adopted the habit of crossing solo. Using space suits as a sort of space bicycle with thrusters that could push them to speeds of up to five hundred kilometers per hour was the easiest means of travel within a few hundred kilometers of the space elevator. By this point, people were flying between the space elevator and the surrounding stations all the time.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 254

He knew that his suit's life-support system would only hold up for twelve hours, and before that time ran out he had to make it eighty kilometers back to Base 1, now just a shapeless point far off in the distance of the abyss of space. The base itself would not survive very long, either, if it left the umbilical cord of the space elevator. But now, as he floated in the vast void, he felt like his contact with the blue world down below had been cut off. He was an independent presence in the universe, unattached to any world, dangling in the cosmos, no ground beneath his feet and surrounded by empty space on all sides, with no origin or destination, like the Earth, the sun, and the Milky Way. He simply existed, and he liked this feeling.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 257

their words included the ones he was expecting: "Meteor shower!"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 257

He knew that the death of the three key aerospace figures did not guarantee that the non-media radiation drive would become the mainstream of spacecraft research, but he had done all he could. No matter what happened next, as far as the watchful eyes of his father in the beyond were concerned, he could now relax.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 258

"In accordance with the Lord's intentions, that's all we can do. The man is an extremely stubborn holdout and a triumphalist, and the Lord doesn't want us to interfere unnecessarily with that type of human. Our attention must be focused on Escapism. The Lord believes that defeatism is more dangerous than triumphalism," Newton said. "If we are to work sincerely and seriously in the service of the Lord, we can't wholly believe the Lord's strategy.

After all, it's just the counsel of a child," Mozi said. Qin Shi Huang knocked his sword on the ground. "Nevertheless, nonintervention is correct as far as this matter is concerned. Let them turn their development in the direction of radiation drive spacecraft. With physics under sophon lockdown, that will be a technological peak that's practically unsurpassable. Not to mention a bottomless abyss into which humanity will pour all of their time and energy and end up with nothing."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 258

"He is indeed dangerous. His faith is rock-solid, he's farsighted and dispassionately ruthless, and he acts with calm resolve. Ordinarily he's precise and serious, but when there's a need he can go outside the lines and take extraordinary action," Confucius said with a sigh. "Just like the First Emperor said, this is the sort of person we lack."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 269

"Let me repeat your words," she said, clapping him on the shoulder. "Life was born in the water and can't exist without it. Your own body is seventy percent water!" Hines bowed his head and looked at the water stains on the floor. Then he shook his head. "That's right, dear. This question tortures me. It's the most incredible thing in the universe."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 271

We call it the 'mental seal.'"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 310

he had been in hibernation for 185 years. He found the doctor's accent peculiar at first, but he soon discovered that although the sounds of standard Mandarin hadn't changed much, it had been stuffed with a large quantity of English words.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 311

Luo Ji heard the hibernator who was about to leave complaining. "You can't pull seniority in front of them. It's the law: Hibernation doesn't count as age, so in the presence of the elderly, you're the younger generation.... Let's go. They've waited in the reception room long enough,"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 322

English, formerly the most widely used language, and Chinese, spoken by the largest population, had blended with each other without distinction to become the world's most powerful language.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 338

Luo Ji stopped and stared at Shi Qiang for a long while, then up at the flying cars in the air. He thought about the heating glass, and finally understood: It was just a wireless power supply. The power source emitted electricity

in the form of microwaves or other EM radiation to form an electric field over a certain space, allowing any equipment within it to draw power through an antenna or resonant coil. Like Shi Qiang had said, even two centuries ago, this technology was entirely ordinary. The only reason it hadn't been commonplace was because the power loss was too great. Only a small portion of the power emitted into a space could be used, but the majority was lost. In this era, however, mature controlled fusion technology meant that energy sources had been greatly enriched, to the point that losses from wireless power supplies were acceptable.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 339

Shi Qiang handed Luo Ji a cigarette and taught him how to twist the filter tip to light it.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 344

"There aren't any computers anymore. Anyone who wants to go online or something can just tap any smooth surface. Clothing and shoes can be used as computers, too. Believe it or not, I've even seen toilet paper that you can go online with." Luo Ji pulled out a napkin.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 348

"You both reacted pretty fast," one bystander said admiringly. "Hibernators. In their era, people had experience with this kind of sudden incident," someone else said. His clothing displayed a swordsman. The duty manager said to Luo Ji and Shi Qiang, "Sirs, this was truly ... Anyway, I guarantee that you'll receive compensation." "Good. Now let's eat." Shi Qiang beckoned Luo Ji to retake his seat, and a human server brought over new dishes to replace those that had spilled.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 348

"Here: to carpe diem, to living one day at a time. One hour at a time, even," Luo Ji said as he raised his glass. "Here's to your still-living son." "Are you really okay?" Shi Qiang said, shooting him a smile. "I've been a messiah. Nothing scares me." He shrugged, then drained his glass. The taste of the alcohol made him wince. "This is like rocket fuel." "You kill me, my boy. That attitude of yours has always killed me," Shi Qiang said, sticking up a thumb.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 349

Luo Ji went over to the sofa, which was hard as marble to the touch. "Is this for sitting?" he asked. At Shi Qiang's affirmative, he sat gingerly down on it, only to feel like he was sinking into soft clay. The sofa's cushions and backrest adapted to a person's body, forming a mold completely in sync with their body shape, keeping pressure to a minimum.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 352

"Killer 5.2." "What?" "It's a network virus. The ETO first released it about a century into the Crisis Era, and then there were lots of subsequent variants and upgrades. It's a murder virus. First it establishes the identity of

the target by a variety of methods including the chip everyone has implanted in their body. When it locates the target, the Killer virus manipulates every possible piece of external hardware to carry out the murder. Its concrete manifestation is what you experienced today. It seems like everything in the world wants to kill you.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 353

This version of Killer is programed specifically to attack Dr. Luo, but because the target was in hibernation, it never had the opportunity to take any concrete action. It stayed dormant and wasn't detected or recorded by the information security system. It was only when Dr. Luo emerged into the world today that Killer 5.2 activated itself and carried out its mission. It's just that its creators were wiped out a century ago." "They were still trying to kill me a century ago?"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 353

"What's on the surface?" Luo Ji asked. Shi Qiang explained, "Most of the reawakened hibernators live on the surface. It's hard for them to adapt down here." "That's right. So you ought to spend at least some time up there," Officer Guo said. "Many aspects of modern society—politics, economics, culture, lifestyle, and relations between the sexes—have changed greatly in two centuries, so it takes some time for us to adapt."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 355

The three fleets had put their primary base on Jupiter because its hydrogen-helium ocean held an inexhaustible supply of fusion fuel. Zhang Beihai was transfixed by the Jovian scene.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 361

Natural Selection was the flagship of the third squadron of the Asian Fleet, and in gross tonnage and performance it was second to none. Possessing the latest non-media fusion propulsion system, at full thrust it could accelerate to 15 percent of the speed of light, and its impeccable internal ecological systems could sustain a long-term voyage. In fact, an experimental version of this system was first put into use on the moon seventy-five years ago and had not yet exhibited any major defects or faults. Natural Selection's weapons were the most powerful in the fleet, too. Its gamma-ray lasers, railguns, high-energy particle beams, and stellar torpedoes made up a four-way weapons system that could obliterate the surface of an Earth-sized planet.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 361

An oval opening appeared in the outer wall of the ship. The craft flew straight inside and came to a halt. The chief of staff opened the cabin door and exited first. Although Zhang Beihai was slightly nervous because he hadn't seen the craft pass through an air lock, he immediately sensed the influx of fresh air from the outside. The technology to maintain a pressurized compartment opening directly into space without allowing air to leak out was not something he had seen before.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 361

Spaceship compartments typically adopted a spherical structure, because during acceleration, deceleration, or change of direction, any point on the sphere could serve as a floor or ceiling, and during weightlessness, the center of the sphere would be the crew's main activity space.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 362

"Dongfang Yanxu, captain of Natural Selection," she said, saluting him. A note of playful challenge appeared in her eyes. "On behalf of the entire crew, I offer a gift to my forbear." She extended her hand, and he saw that, although the object she held in it had changed quite a bit, it was still recognizably a pistol. "If you really find that I have defeatist thinking and Escapist goals, you may use this to kill me."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 367

But later on, things got worse, and the world began to starve. This was about twenty years after Dr. Luo went into hibernation." "Because of the economic transition?" "Right. But environmental deterioration was also a major factor. The environmental laws were there, but in those pessimistic times, the general attitude was, 'What the hell is environmental protection for? Even if Earth turns into a garden, isn't it all going to the Trisolarans anyway?' Eventually, environmental protection was seen as no less treasonous to humanity than the ETO. Organizations like Greenpeace were treated like ETO branches and suppressed. Work on the space forces accelerated the development of highly polluting heavy industry, which made environmental pollution unstoppable. The greenhouse effect, climate anomalies, desertification..." He sighed. "When I entered hibernation, desertification was just starting," another neighbor said.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 369

"Make time for civilization, for civilization won't make time,"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 369

civilization immunity. It means that when the world has suffered a serious illness, it triggers civilization's immune system, so that something like the early Crisis Era won't happen again. Humanism comes first, and perpetuating civilization comes second. These are the concepts that today's society is based on."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 370

"Emancipation of human nature inevitably brings with it scientific and technological progress."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 370

revolutionary slogan is just an adaptation of the old saying from the Golden Age: 'Make time for life, or life won't make time.'

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 370

Make time for civilization, make time for life.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 370

the modern command system had evolved far beyond what he had imagined. The giant spacecraft, equal in volume to three of the largest seagoing carriers of the twenty-first century, was practically a small city, but it had no bridge or command module, or even a captain's room or operations room. In fact, it had no specific functional compartments whatsoever. All of them were identical, regular spheres that differed only in size. At any location inside the ship, you could just use a data glove to activate a holographic display, which, due to the high cost, was a rarity even in Earth's super-wired society.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 370

To Zhang Beihai, it felt like the evolution from a client-server model to a browser-server model in late-twentieth-century computer networks. With the former, you could only access the server through specific software installed on a computer, but using the latter, you could access the server from any computer on the network so long as you had the right permissions. Zhang Beihai and Dongfang Yanxu were situated in an ordinary cabin that, like every other one, had no special instruments or screens. It was just a spherical compartment whose bulkheads were white most of the time, making it feel like the inside of a giant Ping-Pong ball. When gravity was produced by ship acceleration, any part of the spherical bulkhead could be transformed into a shape suitable for use as a chair.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 371

this was another aspect of modern technology that few people had imagined: the elimination of single-purpose facilities.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 372

Under maximum propulsion, the ship's acceleration could reach 120 gs, but this exerted a force more than ten times what a human could tolerate under normal conditions. To go to maximum, they had to enter a "deep-sea state," which consisted of the cabins being filled with an oxygen-rich "deep-sea acceleration fluid" that trained personnel could breathe directly. As they breathed, it would fill their lungs and then the rest of their organs. First dreamed up in the first half of the twentieth century, the liquid was intended at the time to facilitate ultra-deep dives. Pressure was in equilibrium inside and outside of a human body filled with deep-sea acceleration fluid, meaning it could sustain high pressures like a deep-sea fish. The environment of a liquid-filled cabin in a rapidly accelerating spacecraft was like that of the deep sea, so the liquid was now being used to protect human bodies against the ultra-high acceleration of space travel. Hence the term "deep-sea state."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 382

transfer was done via means Zhang Beihai was familiar with: three-factor retina, fingerprint, and passphrase authentication.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 382

Dongfang Yanxu surrendered her pass phrase to Zhang Beihai: “Men always remember love because of romance only.” “You don’t smoke,” he replied calmly. “And the brand was lost during the Great Ravine,” she said with a trace of disappointment, and lowered her eyes. “But the password’s a good one.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 382

“Ancient wisdom,” Dongfang Yanxu said, watching the spot where the door had disappeared, as if trying to see through it. “We’ll never be able to learn the stuff he brought from two centuries ago, but he can learn what we know.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 412

“I wouldn’t usually bother the girls I liked. I believed in what Goethe said: ‘If I love you, what business is it of yours?’”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 412

One day, perhaps, humanity—or maybe someone else—will explore the laws so thoroughly that they’ll be able to alter not only their own reality, but perhaps the entire universe. They’ll be able to turn every star system into whatever shape they require, like kneading a ball of dough. But so what? The laws still won’t have changed. Yes, she’ll still be there, the one unchanging presence, forever young, like how we remember a lover....”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 413

The droplet floated dead center in Mantis’s one spherical main cabin. Its colors were entirely different from the image seen aboard Quantum, paler and softer, evidently due to differences in the scene reflected on its surface—the droplet’s total reflectance meant that it had no color of its own.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 413

“It’s the tear of the blessed mother,” Xizi said.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 413

But Ding Yi watched all of this dispassionately from the rear. “I see something else,” he said. “Something far more sublime. A realm where both self and other are forgotten, an effort to encompass everything by shutting out everything.” “That’s too much philosophy for me to understand,” Xizi laughed through her tears.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 415

“Ten million times.” Macromolecules would be visible at this magnification, but what they saw on the screen remained a smooth mirror without the slightest sign of roughness, no difference in smoothness from the

surrounding unmagnified surface. “Push it up again!” Xizi shook her head. This was the electron microscope’s highest level of magnification.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 415

More than two centuries before, in his novel 2001: A Space Odyssey, Arthur C. Clarke had described a black monolith left on the moon by an advanced alien civilization. Surveyors had measured its dimensions with ordinary rulers and had found a ratio of one to four to nine. When these were rechecked using the most high-precision measurement technology on Earth, the ratio remained an exact one to four to nine, with no error at all. Clarke described it as a “passive yet almost arrogant display of geometrical perfection.” Now, humanity was facing a far more arrogant display of power. “Can an absolutely smooth surface really exist?” Xizi gasped.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 416

Do you know how solid it is? It’s as if the molecules are nailed into place. Even their own vibrations are gone.” “That’s why it’s at absolute zero!”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 416

“What force would allow that?” “There’s only one option: strong interaction.”²³

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 416

The droplet wasn’t fragile like a tear. Entirely the opposite: Its strength was a hundred times greater than the sturdiest material in the Solar System. All known substances were as fragile as paper by comparison. It could pass through the Earth like a bullet through cheese, without even the slightest harm to its surface. “Then ... what’s it here for?” the lieutenant colonel blurted out. “Who knows? Maybe it really is just a messenger. But it’s here to give humanity a different message,” Ding Yi said, turning his gaze away from the droplet. “What?” “If I destroy you, what business is it of yours?”

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 418

By the time it reached the corner, it was traveling at a speed of 31.7 kilometers per second. Now it was on the periphery of the formation, 160 kilometers away from Infinite Frontier, the first warship in this corner of the array. The fragment did not pass by the formation, but executed a thirty-degree turn, and, without slowing down, sped straight toward Infinite Frontier. In the roughly two seconds it took to cover that distance, the computer actually dropped its alert from level two back to level three, concluding that the fragment wasn’t actually a physical object due to the fact that its motion was impossible under aerospace mechanics. At twice the third cosmic velocity, executing a sharp turn without a drop in speed was like slamming into an iron wall. If it was a vessel containing a metal block, the change in direction would have exerted such force as to flatten that metal block into a thin film. So the fragment had to be an illusion. In that manner, the droplet struck Infinite Frontier at twice the third cosmic velocity, at a heading straight along the first row of the fleet rectangle.

70,911mph

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 420

In one minute and eighteen seconds, the droplet had completed a two-thousand-kilometer course, passing through each of the hundred ships in the first row of the combined fleet's rectangular formation. By the time the last ship in the row, Adam, was swallowed up in a nuclear fireball, the bursts of metallic magma at the opposite end had scattered, cooled, and spread out, leaving the heart of the explosion—the spot where Infinite Frontier had been a minute before—empty of practically everything.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 421

For nearly two centuries, research into space strategy and tactics had dreamed up every possible kind of extreme battle condition, but witnessing a hundred warships blowing up like a string of firecrackers in under a minute was beyond what their minds could comprehend.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 422

The fleet's battle monitoring system did not detect the droplet's presence any earlier primarily because it was invisible to radar at all wavelengths and could only be located through analysis of visible spectrum images, but visible images were treated with far less importance than radar data.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 423

The diabolical flight path demonstrated a space drive entirely beyond human comprehension, as if the droplet was a shadow without mass, unconcerned with the principles of dynamics, moving at will like the nib of God's pen. During the attack on the fleet's third row, the droplet's sharp changes of direction occurred at a rate of two or three per second, a deathly embroidery needle sewing a thread of destruction through the row's hundred ships.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 427

But now the combined fleet had to face facts: Their only enemy was a tiny probe, one drop of water out of the enormous ocean of Trisolaran strength, and this probe attacked using one of the oldest and most primitive tactics known to human navies: ramming.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 430

But two other warships successfully accelerated at Ahead Four and escaped the droplet's attack: Quantum and Bronze Age, which had both entered deep-sea state prior to the battle, at Ding Yi's behest. As soon as the third row of ships had been destroyed, the two of them entered Ahead Four and made an emergency escape in the same direction. Their position in a corner of the array, with the entire fleet separating them from the droplet, gave them sufficient time to escape into the depths of space. More than a thousand ships, over half the fleet, had been destroyed in a twenty-minute attack.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 431

The droplet's speed was now ten times the third cosmic velocity, or roughly 170 kilometers per second. Its course took it smashing through debris that liquefied under impact, splashing away at high speed to collide with other debris and giving the droplet a brilliant tail. First it resembled a comet bristling with rage, but as the tail lengthened, it turned into a huge silver dragon that stretched ten thousand kilometers.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 432

Humanity's space-based armed forces had been annihilated. The droplet briefly accelerated in the direction Quantum and Bronze Age had fled, but soon abandoned the chase because the two targets were too far away and had picked up too much speed. And thus, Quantum and Bronze Age became the only survivors of the tremendous destruction. The droplet left the field of slaughter and set its heading in the direction of the sun.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 432

The surviving small craft and fighters drifted for a few days beyond the orbit of Uranus and were eventually rescued by civilian spacecraft plying that region of space. The survivors numbered around sixty thousand, and included the two hibernator officers who had made the first correct assessment of the droplet's attack: Ensign Zhao Xin and Captain Li Wei.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 432

The destruction of the entirety of humanity's space force was accomplished by just one Trisolaran probe, and nine like it were three years away from the Solar System. The ten of them together weren't even one ten-thousandth the size of a single warship, and Trisolaris had a thousand of those that even now were flying onward toward the Solar System. "If I destroy you, what business is it of yours?"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 434

His mind, now freed, took flight, and he imagined the universe as holographic, every point containing the whole, so that the entire universe endured so long as one atom remained. Suddenly he had an all-encompassing sense of focus, the same feeling that Ding Yi had just over ten hours ago at the other end of the Solar System on the last stage of his approach toward the droplet, while Zhang Beihai was still asleep.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 437

Humanity's seven remaining spaceships flew away from the Solar System, split into two groups: five ships comprised of Natural Selection and its pursuers and another group of two ships, Quantum and Bronze Age, which had survived the droplet's devastation.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 459

Blue Space traveled deep into space carrying plenty of fusion fuel and an eight-fold redundant supply of critical parts. There was so much material it was impossible to fit it all inside the craft, so several external storage

compartments were attached to the hull, completely altering the ship's appearance and turning it into an enormous, ugly, irregular body. Indeed, it looked like a traveler on a long journey. The previous year, on the opposite side of the Solar System, Bronze Age had accelerated away from the ruins of Quantum in the direction of Taurus. Blue Space and Quantum had come from a world of light, but they had become two ships of darkness. The universe had once been bright, too. For a short time after the big bang, all matter existed in the form of light, and only after the universe turned to burnt ash did heavier elements precipitate out of the darkness and form planets and life. Darkness was the mother of life and of civilization.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 465

After the Battle of Darkness erupted between the surviving warships in outer space, accusations of Escapism gained new meaning: Recent events had proved that when the spiritual bonds with Earth were snapped, people in space suffered total spiritual alienation. So even if escape were successful, what survived would no longer be human civilization, but some other dark and evil thing. And like Trisolaris, that thing would be the antithesis of human civilization and an enemy of it. It had even been given a name: Negacivilization.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 476

And its destruction was observed: A body traveling close to the speed of light struck 187J3X1. The tiny object—they're calling it a 'photoid'—was observed the instant it passed into the periphery of the stellar atmosphere by the tracks it made. Even though it was small in volume, its near-light velocity meant that its vastly amplified relativistic mass had reached one-eighth of 187J3X1's by the time it struck the target. It destroyed the star immediately. The star's four planets were also vaporized in the blast."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 477

forward, and the people stood up and silently made

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 479

Do you know about mathematical axioms?" "I took geometry in high school. 'Only one straight line can be drawn between two points.' That kind of thing." "Right. So now we're going to set out two axioms for cosmic civilization. First, survival is the primary need of civilization. Second, civilization continuously grows and expands, but the total matter in the universe remains constant." "And then?" "That's it." "What can you derive from those little things?" "The same way you can figure out an entire case from a bullet or a drop of blood, cosmic sociology is able to describe a complete picture of galactic and cosmic civilization from those two axioms.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 480

The amount of matter in the universe remains constant, but life grows exponentially. Exponentials are the devils of mathematics. If there's a microscopic bacterium in the ocean that divides once every half hour, its descendants will fill the entire ocean in the space of a few days, so long as there are sufficient nutrients.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 482

“That’s the chain of suspicion. It’s something that you don’t see on Earth. Humanity’s shared species, cultural similarities, interconnected ecosystem, and close distances means that, in this environment, the chain of suspicion will only extend a level or two before it’s resolved through communication. But in space, the chain of suspicion can be very long. Something like the Battle of Darkness will already have taken place before communication can resolve it.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 483

“That means that the outcome is the same, regardless of whether we’re benevolent civilizations or malicious civilizations?” “That’s right. That’s the most important aspect of the chain of suspicion. It’s unrelated to the civilization’s own morality and social structure.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 483

we need to introduce a second important concept: the technological explosion.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 484

To sum up: one, letting you know I exist, and two, letting you continue to exist, are both dangerous to me and violate the first axiom.” “Da Shi, you’ve really got a clear mind.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 484

“If neither communication nor silence will work once you learn of my existence, you’re left with just one option.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 484

“The real universe is just that black.” Luo Ji waved a hand, feeling the darkness as if stroking velvet. “The universe is a dark forest. Every civilization is an armed hunter stalking through the trees like a ghost, gently pushing aside branches that block the path and trying to tread without sound. Even breathing is done with care. The hunter has to be careful, because everywhere in the forest are stealthy hunters like him. If he finds other life—another hunter, an angel or a demon, a delicate infant or a tottering old man, a fairy or a demigod—there’s only one thing he can do: open fire and eliminate them. In this forest, hell is other people. An eternal threat that any life that exposes its own existence will be swiftly wiped out. This is the picture of cosmic civilization. It’s the explanation for the Fermi Paradox.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 509

The mirrored object reflected a Trisolaran concept that humanity was still trying to figure out. In the words of a well-known Trisolaran saying, “Hiding the self through a faithful mapping of the universe is the only path into eternity.” The antenna was surrounded by a big green meadow that formed a small oasis in the desert of northern China, but this meadow had not been specially planted.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 512

Like the grass, the child running in the distance was bathed in the golden sunset. The sun will set soon. Isn't your child afraid? "Of course she's not afraid. She knows that the sun will rise again tomorrow."
